Shemos 5783

The בית הלוי, in his introduction to ספר שמות, discusses a puzzling series of פסוקים in תהלים (105:24-26):

וַיָּפֶר אֶת עַמּוֹ מְאֹד וַיַּעֲצִמֵהוּ מִצָּרָיו: הָפַךְ לִבָּם לִשְׂנֹא עַמּוֹ לְהִתְנַכֵּל בַּעֲבָדָיו: שָׁלַח מֹשֶׁה עַבְדּוֹ אַהֲרֹן אֲשֶׁר בָּחַר בּוֹ:

The entire מזמור קה discusses the חסדי ה' which Hashem performed for כלל ישראל from the time of the avos through יציאת מצרים. Suddenly, in the middle of all of these שירות and תשבחות, we encounter a jarring פסוק: הָפַךְ לִבָּם לִשְׂנֹא עַמּוֹ - "He changed the מצריים's heart so they should hate us." What טובה is being described here? On the contrary, it seems to diminish the גאולה, as it reveals that ה' caused the מצריים to hate us!

This raises an age-old question: How could it be that after יוסף and his brothers brought such fame and prosperity to מצרים, their descendants became עבדים overnight? The פסוק suggests that ה' was behind this transformation. Why? What עבירה caused this change of heart? Moreover, why is this point included among the חסדי ה' in this פרק?

The מדרש רבה discusses the פסוק of (1:8) וַיָּקָם מֶלֶךְ חָדָשׁ עַל מִצְרָיִם and quotes from sefer הושע (5:7): בַּה' בָּגָדוּ - כִּי בָנִים זָרִים יָלָדוּ עַתָּה יֹאכְלֵם חֹדֶשׁ אֶת חֶלְקֵיהֶם; ה' rebelled against כלל ישראל - They raised, or gave birth to, sons who were זָרִים. כְּשֶׁמֵּת יוֹסֵף הצדיק - When יוסף הצדיק passed away; הֵפֵרוּ בְּרִית מִילָה - They were מפר the ברית מילה; אָמְרוּ נִהְיֶה כַּמִּצְרִים - We should be like מצרים; מִכָּאן אַתָּה לָמֵד שֶׁמִּשֶּׁה מָלָן בִּיצִיאָתָן מִמִּצְרַיִם - Here we find out why משה רבינו had to מל them again when they went out of מצרים; וְכֵיוָן שֶׁעָשׂוּ כֵן - Since they were מפר the ברית; לְהִתְנַכֵּל - הָפַךְ הַקָּדוֹשׁ בָּרוּךְ הוּא הָאַהֲבָה שֶׁהָיוּ הַמִּצְרִיִּים אוֹהֲבִין אוֹתָן לְשִׂנְאָה - ה' caused מצרים to start to hate them; בַּעֲבָדָיו שֶׁנֶּאֱמַר: הָפַךְ לִבָּם לִשְׂנֹא עַמּוֹ - the פסוק we just said in תהלים.

The questions are 1) What did כלל ישראל do? And 2) Why did Hashem do this, what benefit was there to כלל ישראל?

The בית הלוי delves deeper into this מדרש. He notes that the act of being מֵפֵר the ברית מילה does not mean they stopped performing it. On the contrary, they continued to do מילה but followed it with מְשִׁיכָה, a practice of pulling the skin to recreate the appearance of an ערלה. This deceptive act allowed them to outwardly resemble the מצריים while technically fulfilling the מצוה. Their intent was to assimilate while still complying with הלכה. This decision stemmed from a flawed calculation. Fearing their distinction as Jews would bring animosity, they sought to blend in. Yet, they misunderstood the profound significance of ברית מילה: it is not merely a physical act but a declaration of separateness, of being the עם הנבחר. In response, Hashem intervened as an act of חסד. If כלל ישראל would not maintain their separateness, He would ensure it. By turning the hearts of the מצרים to hate them, Hashem preserved the distinction between His people and the nations. This separation was essential for our survival as a unique nation, both then and now.

The בית הלוי further points to a remarkable פסוק in פרשת בא. As בני ישראל left מצרים, they asked the מצרים for their valuables (12:35): וּבְנֵי יִשְׂרָאֵל עָשׂוּ כִּדְבַר מֹשֶׁה וַיִּשְׁאֲלוּ מִמִּצְרַיִם כְּלֵי כֶסֶף וּכְלֵי זָהָב וּשְׂמָלֹת. One would expect the מצריים to begrudgingly comply or resentfully part with their belongings. Yet the next פסוק reveals: וַה' נָתַן אֶת חֵן הָעָם בְּעֵינֵי מִצְרַיִם וַיַּשְׁאִלוּם. Despite the devastation of מכת בכורות, בני ישראל found favor with the מצריים. How could this be? The answer lies in Hashem's control over events. Once כלל ישראל separated themselves by performing the קרבן פסח, the שִׂנְאָה of the מצריים was no longer required. The פסוק is showing us that the whole purpose of giving the מצריים this שִׂנְאָה was to keep us as the עם הנבחר, to keep us separate. Bezras Hashem, we should keep doing all of our מצוות especially ברית מילה. We should have many more of them in our family, we should have a lot of שמחות, and we should see the גאולה שלמה במהרה בימינו אמן!

https://youtu.be/AGJfbZxEAJs